

neighbours **PAKISTAN**

RISING TALIBANI

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

Exactly who was behind the devastating suicide bomb attack on Benazir Bhutto's homecoming rally on October 18 in Karachi, which claimed the lives of over 143 people and wounded more than 545 others, is still shrouded in mystery. Opinion may be increasingly polarised in the country over the wisdom of the decision by the former premier and her Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) to push through with such a large procession despite clear and present danger. But one thing remains unambiguous and that is the threat to Pakistan from rising extremism.

The ongoing investigations point to the attack being carried out by one or more suicide attackers. In fact, Bhutto herself said she had received intelligence from "a brotherly country" before her arrival in Karachi that "four squads of suicide attackers" had been dispatched to Karachi to target her. That is why the vehicle she was travelling in from the airport had been fitted with blast-proof armour plates, bullet-proof glass and electronic jamming equipment that had been requested from—and provided by—the Government. One of Pakistan's most wanted militants, Baitullah Mehsud—accused of masterminding many recent suicide attacks—had also issued a threat to Bhutto through the press. For its part the Government had advised the former premier against a slow-moving procession—"where identifying potential bombers is difficult if not impossible", according to the provincial home secretary—and had offered to fly her from the airport to the rally grounds, which she had refused. PPP says it fears more suicide attacks on Bhutto's residence and the party headquarters at Bilawal House.

Since May 2002, when the first suicide bomb attack took place in Karachi targeting French naval personnel, there have been 56 suicide bomb at-



There have been 56 suicide bomb attacks in the past five years